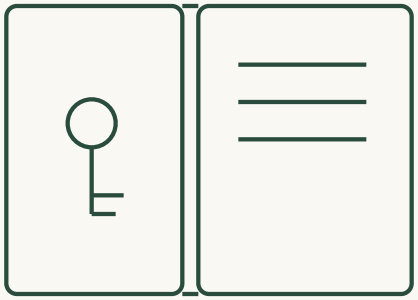
AN ORIGINAL LITERARY MYSTERY

The Lost Manuscript

CASE 01 · THE KEEPER’S LETTER



A letter. Five books. One forgotten folio.

Bellwether Books is about to open its archive. Its oldest story has never reached a reader. Follow the keeper’s paper trail and find where she left the first page.

WHAT YOU NEED

A pencil and these pages. Play alone or share the evidence with another reader. Keep the separate hint and solution booklets closed until you need them.

CASE FILE

The room that kept a secret

By late afternoon, Bellwether Books will be full of people. The lamps are ready, the dust is gone, and the old reading room is opening for the first time in years. Ada Bell, the new keeper, has asked you to help with one last thing.

“Elsie left this for whoever would listen,” she says, sliding an envelope across the counter. Elsie Rowan retired last winter, after forty years of knowing which book every customer needed. She has sent a note instead of attending tonight’s opening.

For decades, the shop’s inventory has carried a curious entry: A Map of Unwritten Hours, an unpublished manuscript by its founder, Elias Rowan. Nobody has seen the pages. Nobody knows whether the book was ever finished.

Inside Elsie’s envelope are a five-line letter and three old records. Her instruction is brief: “Find the first folio. A direction leads to a shelf; the middle book leads to an object. My work log will tell you how to open what you find.”

YOUR TASK
Find the direction, identify the middle book, decode its inscription, and work out the four-digit combination. Everything needed is in the supplied documents. No knowledge of published novels is required.

Work through the documents in order. You may write on these pages or keep your answers on separate paper. The hints offer three levels of help for each step.

DOCUMENT 01 · ELSIE’S ENVELOPE

The five-line letter

The note has five carefully spaced lines. A small pencil remark at the top reads: “Begin well, and you will know where to look.”

No story is lost while someone keeps looking.

Old shelves have longer memories than we do.

Read the room before you read its books.

There is a beginning hidden in every line.

Hold on to the direction when you find it.

— Elsie Rowan

Which direction does Elsie’s note give you?

The reading room has four shelves: NORTH, EAST, SOUTH and WEST. Once you have your direction, the shelf record on the next page will identify the book you need.

DOCUMENT 02 · SHELF RECORD

Five books, one row

On the shelf named by the letter, these five books stand in one straight row. The inventory below is unordered. Reconstruct their positions from left to right, with no gaps.

THE BOOKS
The Weather Atlas · The Quiet Garden · The Dusk Letters · The Hidden River · The Glass Orchard

1. The Glass Orchard is immediately to the left of The Quiet Garden.

2. The Weather Atlas is immediately to the right of The Hidden River.

3. The Quiet Garden is somewhere to the left of The Weather Atlas.

4. The Dusk Letters is somewhere to the left of The Glass Orchard.

1	2	3	4	5

Which book occupies the middle position?

Use only that book’s inscription in the catalogue on the next page.

DOCUMENT 03 · PRIVATE CATALOGUE

Words facing the mirror

Each book has a short inscription pencilled on its catalogue card. Elsie's instruction is written above the entries:

> "Pair the alphabet's first letter with its last, its second with its second-last, and so on. Replace each letter in the inscription with its partner."

Book	Inscription
The Hidden River	WIZDVI
The Glass Orchard	XSVHG
The Weather Atlas	OVGGVI
The Dusk Letters	YLLPH
The Quiet Garden	XOLXP

Alphabet reference

A B C D E F G H I J K L M

N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z

The middle book's inscription decodes to:

This word identifies an object in the reading room. Elsie says its wooden base contains a small locked drawer.

DOCUMENT 04 · KEEPER’S WORK LOG

The moment she finished

A label inside the wooden base directs you to Elsie’s work log. The drawer has a four-digit combination. Her margin note explains how she set it:

> “I began at 09:45. These tasks followed one another, in the listed order, with no overlaps or other breaks. After the final task, I set the combination to the time I finished.”

Task	Duration
Polish the archive plates	22 minutes
Replace the shelf labels	17 minutes
Wrap the light-sensitive papers	26 minutes
Inspect the wooden base	15 minutes

Write the finishing time in 24-hour form. Then remove the colon, keeping both hour digits and both minute digits. That gives the four-digit combination.

Finishing time:

Four-digit combination:

RECOVERY REPORT

Bring the evidence together

Before opening the solution booklet, make sure you can explain the whole route. A convincing answer connects every document.

1. Direction given by the letter

2. Book in the middle of the reconstructed shelf

3. Object named by that book’s inscription

4. Four-digit drawer combination

How do the documents support your discovery?

THE ENVELOPE IS READY
When you have your route and combination, open the separate solutions booklet for the explanations and the story’s ending. If one step remains unclear, use its hints first.